



Chapter Twenty-Four

• 3.24.1 • 3.24.2 •

EXPLANATION

01



TITUS

I can tell he's been crying from the redness in his eyes. His expression surprises me enough that my first words stick to the back of my throat.

I figured he'd be furious. I thought he'd burn my house to ashes, or call upon the strength of his clan to capture everyone I care for, but instead he's at a loss for words, as if he'd been carefully rehearsing them since he started walking over here.

His lips part to speak, but I beat him to it. "Call the Carmine off, Romin. Please. I know what you're thinking. I had no part in what happened."

Reasoning with Romin is like moving a boulder; in most cases pushing does nothing. But he surprises me.

"They're not coming," he says. "It's just me." I can tell he musters every inch of respect he has for me to restrain himself. In place of a response, he trembles in either anger or sorrow, or both, unable to muster a reply or a question, which urges me to continue. I don't know how long the rage he's repressed for me will hold.

I'm smart enough not to mention the young cadets, which leads me to the decision: do I spin him a convincing lie or tell him the whole truth? The image of his honorless death still shakes me to the core, and just seeing his face digs up the most painful traumas of all the emotions I went through in that last life. I can't involve him. I can't let him die the same way, and as much as I long to embrace my childhood friend, no matter if he'll jokingly call me a faggot, to feel he's still alive in a time before hubris and rigor mortis decayed his corpse to maggots and bone—I feel the same repulsive force that separates me from Sylvia drive a gaping rift between the two of us.

I was told once that compassion means "to suffer with," but all I can give him is freedom from the suffering that I'll accept for him, from the pain he'll never have to know. I shut out the voice from within that screams and pleads for me to reach out. I've silenced it for as long as I can remember, at least as long as I've denied the feelings that stir within me when I try to lose myself in the tenderness of Sylvia's embrace. They're only illusions of debt she's grown since I first protected her. All I do is walk the line of the same path life has decided for me, from my loveless fight for value in the orphanage to the words of the Academy that we were all born a sacrifice to the Greater Good.

And so I find no trepidation in accepting this truth. I don't think too hard when I make the choice—I can carry that remorse.

"Clint didn't check the basement when we sold the shop to the Carmine," I say. "I still had a spare key. There's a lot of family treasure down there we couldn't afford to have disappear."

"Then why did you run? Why did you look so afraid and guilty? How could you not have known something was happening? I want to believe you," Romin insists, pausing as his mind collects the next words, "because you're my closest friend and brother. I wouldn't give anybody else, but you, the benefit of the doubt for the horrible things I saw . . . tonight. There were two young Brothers and Sisters that came to me from beneath the cellar. They said you saved them. You fought the Merlot when they tried to kill all our young cadets."

"I did, Romin. I couldn't just stand there and do nothing."

"Thank you, Titus," he says. "Those Gods-damn Merlot, fridging bastards, to think they could stoop as low as murdering innocent children!" Romin's anger has now taken a side.

"They weren't Merlot."

"And how would you know that?"

"I . . ." can't explain to him what I know. "I don't," I say instead.

"I knew it. I knew there was no way it could have anything to do with you. But those Merlot suck-ups—" he trembles with rage, growing twice his size with how he tensions his muscles, finally free to channel the vitriol— "better prepare for what's coming their way."

I don't notice when another familiar face approaches.

"Even Valentina will—"

"Will what?" Valentina says. She looks so small compared to him, even when she climbs a step higher on the porch. Valentina keeps an arm-and-a-half reach, as if Romin were a snake coiled to attack. And if I were her, I would do the same.

Romin says, "So are you always going to cover for the horrible things the Merlot has done?"

"I would only ever apologize for the things my people have done," Valentina says. "Fifteen years and you're ready to throw all of that out the window for your anger." She's not afraid, but she ought to be. I begin to wonder if this conversation happened in that life before, because all I saw was the bitter aftermath. "All I've ever asked for is just for you to just listen to me!"

I can't tell them what I really saw. I refuse to burden them. All I can do is watch as the conversation plays out.

"Your words mean nothing—how you speak so highly of the family that disowns you." Romin encroaches the territory of that secret she hides within her heart. "Paid off by Daddy to breathe air with your bastard blood," he says; "you call yourself free and strong when you're too weak to live by your own terms. Your words are just like your family: fake and hollow."

Lyra and Sylvia now approach, looking on in horror, refusing to react either. Lyra and Sylvia don't have an inkling of what Romin speaks of. But I've been cursed with that knowledge.

Valentina trembles. Her fists ball so hard on her well-manicured nails that I think they'll draw blood. Her signature eyeshadow doesn't run with streaks of black from tears: all the anger inside must have vaporized them, leaving nothing but the poisonous pathos of every scar she can re-open. Knowing Romin better than any of us, she doesn't hesitate.

In fact, she draws closer.

"I should have known better than to think you'd listen! Your head's so far up your ass living in the past, you don't even try to understand," she says, "and I thought you were different than all your Carmine cultist brothers and sisters."

I can see Romin's anger escalate. Something's gotta give.

"The only place you'll ever live and die is in the shadow of your brother."

"You fucking insolent bitch!"

Romin brandishes the back of his hand across her face. It takes so little of his force to send her flying across the porch and into the shutters, right next to the glass where my head slammed hours earlier. They snap from the force of her whole body. Romin looks on in terror as she lies on the ground, motionless, unsure of what to do or what to say, as his humored drivel can't salvage the severity of this irreversible outburst.

I should have gotten between them. I should have said something. And as Sylvia reaches to try to lift her from the ground, Romin begins to tremble, mumbling incoherent words when he sees the limpness in her body.

I have no words for Romin, just as he has no actions, drowning in his own thoughts as his head sinks in his hands. He sits on the porch, refusing to leave, but also too afraid to help her.

"What in Gods' name were you thinking, Romin?" Sylvia says. She takes Valentina inside. "All you can ever do is just solve problems with your fists!"

"I know. I know . . ." Romin mutters to himself between a snuffle, like a mantra, too focused as he stares at his open palms, wondering how such little force can cause such destruction.

"She's breathing," Sylvia says. "Just shocked."

"Take her inside," Lyra instructs. "I'll see what I can do."

"Are you medically trained? Are you in the Academy?" Sylvia asks. Lyra explains something about Essence, but I don't catch the end of their conversation.

I find myself sitting next to Romin. The lamps of lighttime flash on and I wonder how much time we have left.

"Live fast and die young, talk with your fists and burn out strong," he mutters. "No mother. No father. And only a single image of blood for me to live for."

It's only the memory of his last life that gives me a shred of sympathy. I don't give him the grace of a reply yet. All I want is to listen.

"Sometimes it feels like I could just stand up and slit my throat, and the entire world would go on without me, without a hitch. There's something I have to convince myself of, when I've already lived longer than I ever thought I would," Romin says. His eyes leak, but he'd never call them tears.

"But why?"

"Because I keep trying to fill the shoes that were left for me. And all that happened was I kept getting smaller." He tensions his fists. "I just get so jealous of her . . . not that she didn't work to build that image of hers. But she didn't struggle. Not like us, Titus, on the ground, raised from nothing," and he turns to face me, tears in his eyes, "with no wind in our sails or a voice of love or reason to tell us what we're worth, how in the Gods' name does that not bother you?"

"Because I'm always running from it," I tell him. "I run so fast that it can't catch up."

"And how does that make you feel anywhere close to complete?"

"It doesn't," I tell him. "And I don't understand either."

I see that trademark shit-eating grin crest his face—but his expression doesn't brighten enough to make me think he dismisses his own actions. Around us, the city begins another day with the early risers. Young fireteams of pre-academy cadets run in formation. Other windows flash in with fluorescent light. But still the smog covers the city, obscuring the mountains and the beautiful world somewhere far beyond.

"Then I guess that makes two of us," he says.

"You should feel terrible for how you hurt her, but you already know that, and I don't have to tell you twice. All I want you to know is that I understand it, that pain you feel," I tell him. "Because I look at Sylvia, and with such a smog-ridden, corrupt, disgusting, lonely, agonizing world we live in, I'm still trying to figure out what lets her smile."

I look out at the civilians, wondering how much time they have left, wondering how they would react if they knew the end was approaching so soon.

"Here's to the answer," he says, raising an invisible glass. He won't leave: his guilt and disappointment trap him here. "Go in there and check on her."

"I will," I say.

"And hey—" he catches me before I turn for the door. "An angry piece of shit like me doesn't deserve a sincere friend like you, Titus. But thank you for not giving up on me. Thank you for being honest."

I nod before turning for the door. My stomach drops with that word. Honest. If I were honest, you would all be horrified, but I don't let that thought cleanse my personal sins as they chew away at my heart.

02



TITUS

"She's fine, just a little shaken up," Sylvia insists. "Maybe a concussion."

"I did what I could with Essence," Lyra adds.

Valentina's awake, just dazed, absorbed by the pain in her head, trying to take in her surroundings. She lays on the couch, more concerned about the mud on her boots than her own condition, resting her heels on the carpeted floor.

She speaks up. "I wasn't here for Romin. I was here for you, Titus," she says, tilting her head to try to meet my eyes, but the brim of her hat conceals them. "Your panic. All the things you knew that I never told you: my secret, the cellar, and the

lift. I thought it was a joke at first — I can read people well because I play them, and I know you weren't lying."

"It's about time you told us," Lyra says.

"Alright, then," I say. I look towards the door where Romin still sulks on the porch, trapped there, feeling to guilty to either leave or enter. "Can I call him in?"

Lyra and Sylvia look to Valentina.

"Go ahead. This is important," she says.

I approach the entryway, calling his name. He turns sideways to fit through the door, head bowed, afraid to meet eyes with Valentina.

"No words I say can excuse myself. I'm an angry piece of shit like always, and I'm sorry for that," Romin says.

"I instigated you," Valentina says. "But still, why . . ." Her words freeze.

Silence hangs between us for a moment before discomfort urges her to speak again.

"Anyways, Titus. Go on."

Romin sits on the couch next to me, across from Valentina, with Lyra and Sylvia directly behind her. Lighttime filters through the grand, marbled living room window, and I doubt any of them will believe me, so I dump the hardest truth all at once.

"I lived an unthinkable future and died. I saw the end of Blackwater. A great Chymaeran flood called Endogeny eviscerated every living thing, killing all the lower peoples, draining their Essence so the Afterlife could thrive."

I gauge their expressions. Romin tries to keep a straight face. Sylvia nods. Lyra looks surprisingly convinced, and Valentina's in dazed disbelief.

"Endogeny," Lyra says. "Made from the ashes of a Chymaeran God fused with the soul of a cursed Chymaeran Mask, forever hungry. Deterrable by the Essenced, and brutal to the weak-blooded. The First Red know much of it. In fact, we were almost certain it would be our end."

"Hold on a second," Romin says. "Are you telling us you came from the First Red? Of the Carmine?"

"It's true," Lyra says. "We operate in secret. We live beyond the walls, controlling the operations of the Carmine from afar. You don't see us. But we are everywhere."

"She's lying, Titus," Romin says. "That's a myth! The Blackwater Carmine is the only relic that remains of that past purpose. We pick up the pieces our founders left behind. They all died—along with my mother and father!"

"She's telling the truth, Romin," I say, "I saw them there at the summit, too late to act."

Lyra casts a flame in her hands. Romin and Valentina are dumbfounded. "There's so much all of you never learned. Those upper bastards herd you like cattle, depriving you of your birthright as Humans as a means to their sickening end."

Valentina adds: "But how could my family ever comply with that? We relay the will of the Afterlife, and they care for us. All of us! Why does Blackwater never starve, besides being in a frostbitten wasteland? The Merlot carries their will, and their will is good."

"This girl here," Lyra says. "Valentina? What's your relation?"

"I'm the daughter of the Province Twelve Merlot," she replies.

"You haven't seen her movies?" Romin says.

"No, I haven't," Lyra says. "How can you be so blind to what they're doing?"

"I don't think my mother and father even understand their full intentions. Rich as they are, they're still public servants."

"No wonder you and Beefcake don't get along," Lyra says.

"Let's stay on topic," I interject. I think of the whole truth I'm withholding from them every time our eyes meet. Valentina crushed to nothing. Romin a martyr. Vera dying alongside me, and Sylvia losing control of whatever energy it is that resides within her.

Surrounded by the friends and allies I've pleaded fate to see alive and well, I've never felt so helplessly alone.

"I believe Titus," Lyra says. "He's spoken of things nobody ever could have known. He knew the fire would destroy the trade house. He tried to save those children."

"How did you know?" Romin asks.

"The last time, all I got was a call from my father across the street," I say. "I saw the wreckage. Innocent cadets murdered before the burnings. The perpetrators dressed as Merlot though they're really the Afterlife."

"And what happened after that?"

"Chaos. Looting. Street wars that weakened the fabric of our city enough for Endogeny to destroy everything," I say.

"And the Carmine are furious. They'd have Valentina's head if they saw her on the way over here," Romin says.

Sylvia leans forward on the couch. "So when does this all happen?"

"Soon. Maybe even now," I tell her.

"And what happens next?"

"The fire. I came down as quickly as I could. Then . . . Ellie!"

How could I have forgotten about her so easily?

"What about her?" Lyra asks. "She's safe upstairs, and we've been down here the whole time."

"Ellie!" I shout. "Ellie, are you ready?"

No reply.

"Ellie, please, say something!"

Nothing.

My stomach drops. I climb the stairs.

"Ellie! Ellie, come here," My voice wavers. But still—no reply comes from her room.

The door is closed, and I see the light on beneath the crack of the door. It's freezing: even colder than the early afternoon air outside.

I'm reassured by the crack of light.

My hands reach for the doorknob.

"Ellie, you have to respond to me. You scare me when you don't reply like that," I say, as I open the door. There's ice frosting the windows. The window is open. It looks as if dew freezes her sheets to the bed.

She sits there on the mattress. Her hair blows with the wind.

"What were you thinking, opening the window? You're going to catch a cold."

She doesn't reply, and I don't see any of the mannerisms I know. It's as if she's hollow—like the brass statues at the Academy, filled with nothing—because her soul and self has left. The more I look at her, the more I notice something is off. The uncanny resemblance is something that only I could ever notice.

I wear a thick coat, but I still shiver. That frigidness has come from within. I'm scared to speak the next words because of what might happen.

My voice flattens. "Who are you?"

And that's when I find out.